# THE MAKING OF INDIA'S ACE OF PACE

**Coaches and friends in Ahmedabad recall the lanky, shy boy with an unusual action**

One downside of having a cricketing hero for a friend is that even an ordinary outing has to be timed carefully. Public spaces are safest post midnight, when the crowds thin and the risk of being mobbed for selfies is lower. Gujarat pacer Chintan Gaja, former captain of the state's Ranji team and a close friend of Jasprit Bumrah, has seen it once too often. "Earlier, we played PS2 (video game) and he was very competitive; he never liked to lose. Now we have equally competitive duels over pickleball," he says.

While Bumrah's searing yorkers are the worst nightmares for the best batters in the world, in Ahmedabad, they still evoke old memories. Kirat Damani, a lawyer and chairman of the Gujarat Ranji Trophy selection committee, recalls the first time he noticed Bumrah bowling on the grounds of MG Science College. "A wiry boy storms the pitch with lightning pace, bounce and accuracy. He was exceptional," he says.

Yet Bumrah's unusual bowling action drew scepticism early on. Some felt the pronounced hand movement would tire him out by the time he reached first-class cricket. Coaches occasionally urged him to alter his technique, even as they recognised his obvious ability. But Bumrah stuck on. "Back then, as teenagers, it was not easy to be mocked at," says Priyank Panchal, a former Gujarat captain and three years his senior in the team. "He (Bumrah) somehow had the clarity that this was not his weakness, but strength. He did not let the criticism affect him."

This quiet resolve was shaped early. Bumrah was five when he lost his father, Jasbir. He and his elder sister, Juhika, were raised by their mother Daljit, the principal of Nirman High School in Ahmedabad's Vastrapur neighbourhood—also Bumrah's alma mater. Running a modest middle-class household meant living with financial uncertainty, but Daljit always encouraged her son's passion for cricket.

Friends from those years remember how completely the game absorbed him. "I recall him as a quiet boy who was either playing cricket or reading and learning about cricket," says Himanshu Nainani, a childhood friend who lived in the same apartment complex as Bumrah in Ahmedabad's Drive-In area. For coaches who worked with him in the domestic circuit, Bumrah's rise was as much about a "strong work ethic" as talent. Hitesh Majumdar, who was a key member of the coaching staff when Bumrah made his T20 debut for Gujarat in the 2012–13 Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, recalls a cricketer who "played with his brain, not brawn".

At Nirman School's central hall, two soft boards display photographs and newspaper cuttings tracing Bumrah's rise. A framed photograph hangs nearby, captioned simply: "Jasprit Bumrah, we are proud of you."

Success has brought visible changes. Bumrah and his mother have moved from the modest two-bedroom apartment to an upscale gated neighbourhood off Ambli Road, popularly known as 'Billionaire Street'. A Maybach parked outside signals the transformation. Bumrah's wife, sports journalist Sanjana Ganesan, and their son Angad, divide their time between Ahmedabad and Mumbai.

***—Jumana Shah***



GETTY IMAGES

« **SUPPORT SYSTEM** Bumrah with his wife, Sanjana Ganesan, and mother, Daljit

**Running a modest middle-class household meant constant financial uncertainty, but Daljit always encouraged her son's passion for cricket**

strategy. To continue with that approach years later—even in international cricket, where conditions can sometimes offer a bowler relief through movement—reveals a deeper quality about Bumrah: courage.

When even the best bowlers in the world opt for a wide line outside off stump against a batter on the rampage—sometimes risking multiple wides simply to avoid being clobbered—Bumrah chooses a far braver option. When faced with a batter in full flow, the Indian spearhead continues to attack rather than retreat. Mike Tyson once famously said: "Everyone has a plan until they get punched in the face." That quote has served as a universal reference point in competitive sport for decades. Bumrah, it seems, is on a mission to make it redundant.